Japanese American Citizens League
2026 National Scholarship Program Guidelines

The 2026 National JACL Scholarship Program has moved to online applications. An informational brochure, instructions, and applications are now posted on the National JACL website (www.jacl.org). Click "Youth" on the menu bar to access the scholarship program webpage. The scholarship categories offered are Freshman, Undergraduate, Graduate, Law, Creative Arts, Performing Arts, and Student Financial Aid.

FRESHMAN -- All freshman applications must be submitted **directly by the applicant to National JACL through the online form** no later than **Monday, March 2, 2026 at 11:59 p.m. Hawaiian Standard Time (HST).**

Following this, National will forward these applications to their respective chapters for review. Chapters will have one month to evaluate and rate their applications, and are to forward the names of **ONLY** the most outstanding applicants to National JACL at scholarships@jacl.org no later than **Friday, April 3, 2026, 11:59 p.m. Hawaiian Standard Time (HST).**

There is no limit to the number of outstanding freshman applicants that each chapter may forward to the National level. HOWEVER, chapters are asked to ensure that ONLY the truly "outstanding" applications make their way to the national competition. The selection committee has found that too many chapters are not conducting a thorough review of their freshman applications.

OTHER GRADE LEVELS -- The Undergraduate, Graduate, Law, Creative Arts, Performing Arts and Student Financial Aid applications must be submitted through the online form no later than **Friday, April 3, 2026, 11:59 p.m. Hawaiian Standard Time (HST).**

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To All Applicants: All applications must be on the **2026 application form** that is posted on the JACL website **(www.jacl.org)**.. **Note:** the required Personal Statement essay prompt changes each year, so students must use the 2026 application for consideration by the National Scholarship Committees.

One must hold an individual or youth membership in the JACL. A family membership under one's parent(s) is NOT accepted.

All applications **must be complete** by the stated deadlines in order to be considered. **PLEASE watch for any emails from scholarships@jacl.org for any possible notifications about incomplete applications or missing materials.** Applications and required materials must be submitted through the form unless other methods for

submission are stated on the form (i.e., transcripts, letter of recommendation, photo.) Incomplete applications will **NOT** be accepted or considered by the committees.

Students are allowed to apply to **ONE CATEGORY ONLY:** Freshman, Undergraduate, Graduate, Law, Creative Arts, or Performing Arts. **The exception to this rule is that ANY applicant may also apply for the Student Financial Aid Scholarship** in addition to another category. However, a successful applicant will only receive the higher of the two awards applied for.

Applicants are judged based on their JACL involvement, scholastic achievement, extra-curricular activities, community involvement, personal statement, and letter of recommendation.

Requirements:
-JACL Membership (Individual or Youth/Student)
-Personal Statement
-A Letter of Recommendation
-Official transcripts (only one copy required from each school)
-Photo (headshot)

In September 2026, the scholarship recipients will have been determined, and an electronic notification will be made to all applicants. The JACL chapters to which the awardees belong will be notified as well. In the Fall of 2026, the JACL national newspaper, the Pacific Citizen, will publish its annual Scholarship Edition highlighting all of the award recipients.

One must be enrolled in school in the Fall of 2026 to receive a scholarship.
Past recipients are limited to a total of two National JACL Scholarships.
Professional artists are NOT eligible to apply for either of the two arts scholarships offered.

If you have any questions, please contact Scholarship Program Manager Matthew Weisbly at scholarships@jacl.org.

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